"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

Late Edition
Today, sunny, a brisk wind, quite cool, high 47. Tonight, clear, diminishing winds, chilly, low 29. Tomorrow, mostly sunny, light winds, high 49. Weather map, Page D8.

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Boycott Tarnishes Gold Medal Dreams

The team photo, 28 years young, hangs in an office at home, symbolic of what was, and was not.

Only with reflective pauses do the names return, as if memories must be unlocked, one by one. "Holly Warlick was on the team . . . Denise Curry . . . Lynette Woodard," Carol Blazejowski said. "Sue Gunther was the coach . . . Pat Summitt was her assistant."

HARVEY ARATON
SPORTS OF THE TIMES

They were all part of a United States women's national basketball team that played in the 1979 Pan Am Games in San Juan and in the 1980 pre-Olympics qualifying tournament in Sofia, Bulgaria. Then the road to Moscow was famously (or infamously, if you prefer) blocked by the Carter administration boycott. A photo was all that remained of a gold medal dream.

"What I remember is that some of the players felt, Well, it's tough luck, but I have to support my country," Blazejowski said. "And others felt, I just spent all these years preparing to compete."

And the high-scoring Jersey girl from little Montclair State, the one they reverently called the Blaze? "My reaction was more reality than apple pie and red, white and blue," she said. "For me, it was about the years I'd put in. I did feel that we unfortunately were innocent victims."

Be it understandable resentment or just plain sorrow, those feelings remain, however deeply embedded in the brain of a basketball lifer who moved on, who for the last decade has been general manager and president of the Liberty of the W.N.B.A.

Blazejowski is not so unique

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OLYMPICS

Boycott Tarnishes Gold Medal Dreams

From First Sports Page

with her sad Olympic tale. There is even a Madison Square Garden colleague, at least for the time being, who can relate.

Like Isiah Thomas, the point guard for the Dave Gavitt-coached men's team that fateful year, Blazejowski had to deal with further Olympic rejection. Thomas was left off the 1992 Dream Team, presumably as Michael Jordan's enemy. All Blazejowski did was get paid, and not very much, by a women's pro league lasting one season, making her ineligible to compete at the 1984 Los Angeles Games.

"And now you have LeBron James and all these multimillionaires," she said more matter-of-factly than ruefully.

What can you say about a hurricane of hypocrisy that so arbitrarily chooses its victims? In a new book about the 1980 Olympic boycott to be released in May, Walter Mondale, the vice president under Jimmy Carter, writes in the foreword, addressing the athletes, "First of all, I'm very sorry about it." But he adds, "I still think it was the right thing to do."

The book, "Boycott: Stolen Dreams of the 1980 Moscow Olympic Games" (New Chapter Press), is a collaboration of brothers, Tom and Jerry Caraccioli, revisiting Carter's decision to punish the Soviets for their aggression in Afghanistan. Mostly, they profile 18 athletes, including Blazejowski and Thomas, who, in Mondale's words, "were asked to pay a price that couldn't be repaid."

In a 2006 book, the Caracciolis wrote about the largely forgotten 1972 American silver medalist hockey team. When editors asked for a sequel, they volunteered the Moscow nonstarters, timing the book's release to the coming Beijing Summer Games.

"It being China, we thought it was a theme that could materialize again," Tom Caraccioli said.

Even with protests of Chinese policy on Darfur compounded by the recent unrest in Tibet, there is no widespread advocacy for a Beijing boycott, but there is enough of an anticipatory buzz for Olympic officials to insist they are not planning to stage one.

In an interview this week with The Associated Press, Jacques Rogge, the International Olympic Committee president, argued that far more good would come from having the world's athletes and news media in China than not. Peter Ueberroth, who heads the United States Olympic Committee, recently said, "Boycotts do one thing very well and only one thing: they punish athletes."

Among others. The 1984 Summer Games, organized by Ueberroth, were a financial success but were qualitatively tainted by the Soviets' returning Carter's fire. From the athlete's perspective, what else but retaliation did Carter accomplish, or expect?

"I always thought that sports was the unifier of the world, quite frankly," Blazejowski said.

For all the calls to preserve the purity of sport, separate from the manipulations of the state, when, exactly, has that been the case? And how many would argue that the decades-long exclusion from the Olympic movement of South Africa because of its apartheid policies was a bad thing?

Generally speaking, self-interest is more the standard policy, business as usual. This year, no matter how much the heat may get turned up, Ueberroth will probably not forget that China did go to Los Angeles, ending its long Olympic prohibition related to the country now competing as Chinese Taipei.

He knows that what goes around can come around for a sports powerhouse that, since last serving as the aggrieved Olympic host months after 9/11, has come to be seen by a fair number of nations through the walls of its own glass house.

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